

The Engagement Games

Most dogs aren't born with a supernatural ability to concentrate. They experience the world at intensities far stronger than ours, every smell, every sound, every movement felt more deeply than anything we notice.

Since a dog can only focus on one thing at a time, it's either the environment that is going to be interesting or you are.

For your dog to choose you over everything else, you need to build something real.

A desire to be with you and enjoy it.

A true bond.

And in this next part of the course, you are going to learn 5 games that will help you start building that bond, step by step.

Ping Pong

If there is one game I would play with every dog in the world, it's this one. Ping Pong teaches your dog to choose you. Not because you asked, but because they want to.

Why do we play this game?

To teach your dog to return to you quickly after noticing a distraction in the environment.

What makes this game special is that you can choose what to reinforce at any given moment. You can reinforce the chase after the treat, the act of eating, the moment they lift their head from the floor, a glance from a distance, the first step back toward you, the stop in front of you, a moment of static eye contact — always according to the right criteria for your dog.

This way, the dog is the one who leads the conversation, and we answer.

How to play

Start by positioning yourself next to your dog, holding treats in both hands.

When your dog looks at you, use a marker that says "Chase a Treat" and toss a treat to one side, in a line your dog can track. Once they find the treat and look back toward you, use your Keep Going marker followed by the Chase marker, and toss to the other side.

This creates the back-and-forth flow that gives the game its name. When your dog understands the game well and is turning back to you immediately after each chase, start raising from the ground until you reach a full standing position, and begin adding motion to the game without confusing your dog.

Once the chasing game feels easy and natural, move to the next level: wait for static eye contact, praise with your Keep Going marker, and only then toss the next treat.

When your dog can stay in control in a neutral environment, start adding distractions. Begin with distractions you can control, from a distance your dog can handle, and slowly get closer. Gradually introduce moving distractions.

As your dog becomes more confident, keep adding new environments and more challenging distractions to your training — until your dog can play this game no matter the environment.

A few things to keep in mind:

Some dogs will take a moment to sniff the ground after eating the treat. With these dogs, use your Keep Going marker with excitement as soon as they finish eating, before they drop their nose. This can help them learn the pattern of coming back up and returning to you rather than lingering on the ground.

When you're just starting out with this game, feel free to reward only through treat tossing. But as you progress, start working on the static reward. Your dog chases a treat, you use your Keep Going marker as they turn back to you, and then wait for them to stop in front of you with eye contact. That moment of eye contact is the behaviour to confirm with your Static Confirmation marker, followed by a Chase.

For some dogs, stopping and staying with you before the chase may become a challenge if they are not mentally ready for it yet. Read your dog and choose the style that fits where they are right now.

Reinforce & Release

The Reinforce & Release game is my favorite game to teach any dog I start working with, whether they are a dancing dog or a life companion. It teaches your dog that staying with you is always their choice, and coming back is always worth it.

Why do we play this game?

The concept of duration — staying focused until you give the release
A self-initiated check-in and default position in front of you
A strong Keep Going marker within your communication system
The ability to engage in new environments without pressure —
because every time your dog comes back to you, it's their choice

I also love using this game at the start of every session. The way your dog plays it tells you immediately how easy or difficult the environment is for them that day. It's one of the best reads you can get before you start training anything else.

How to play

Wait for your dog to offer you even the smallest signal of attention, a glance, a step toward you, anything. The moment they do, use your Keep Going marker and deliver a treat from your hand.

Once they've eaten that treat, take one step back. Use your Keep Going marker again to signal that eating the treat was the right move, and place a second treat in your hand. When they eat the second treat, take another step back, use your Keep Going marker, and offer a third treat.

After the third treat, use your Release marker and toss a treat behind you. Let your dog chase it.

The moment they raise their head from the ground and start searching for you, mark with your Keep Going marker, and start the whole sequence again.

This back-and-forth of focus, treat, following your movement, and focus again, often ending in a release, is what keeps this game fun and engaging for your dog. It feels easy to them, basically getting

treats for eating treats and then being released, and because it's so much fun to play, they learn to wait for the release before disengaging.

Once your dog understands the pattern well and is checking back in with you quickly after each release, start playing in busier, more distracting environments. As your dog becomes more confident, keep raising the challenge until they can play this game no matter where you are.

A few things to keep in mind:

Keep your feeding hand steady. Place treats into it rather than lifting your hand to reach for each one. This small detail helps your dog stay focused between treats instead of breaking their attention to follow your hand movement.

If your dog struggles to stay focused for three treats, start with one treat and release, then two and release, and build from there. There's no rush. The goal is that they feel successful, not pressured.

Start this game in an easy environment — somewhere with minimal distractions and enough space for your dog to chase the release treat comfortably. As the game becomes natural to them, you can gradually take it into busier, more challenging places.

Some dogs will find this game easier to start while their handler sits down. If needed, go down to your dog's level until they feel comfortable with the game and can start playing it with real motion.

Sometimes, instead of tossing a treat on the floor with your release marker, simply turn and walk away. This teaches your dog that the release signal means genuine disengagement — not just a cue that a treat is coming. Varying between the two keeps the meaning of the marker clear and honest.

Luring

Luring is one of my go-tos when I train a dog. For me it's not just a way to teach tricks, it's a real tool for conversation. Simple, clear, and confidence-building. Perfect for beginner dogs and handlers alike.

Why do we play this game?

To teach your dog a solid understanding of your hand motion, first of all. But there's much more to luring than just that.

Teaching your dog proper luring helps them understand the difference between a Keep Going marker and a Confirmation marker. It builds confidence and allows your dog to discover new movements and positions with clarity. And most importantly, it builds trust, because your dog has to believe both in you and in themselves while they follow.

How to play

Place a treat between two fingers and your thumb so it is easy for your dog to notice and reach. When your dog makes their first attempt to get it, use your Static Confirmation marker and remove your thumb so they can access the treat.

Repeat a few times until your dog gains confidence in approaching your hand. Then, when they do, start using your Keep Going marker before the confirmation so that they understand they are doing well and that the treat will come soon.

Slowly start moving your hand slightly so they need to follow it and maintain contact with it while in motion, without having full access to the treat. After a small movement, use your Confirmation marker and release the treat.

Keep building duration in both hands until you can increase the difficulty by adding more steps, changing the tempo, and trying different directions and shapes.

A few things to keep in mind

It is not enough for your dog to know how to follow each hand separately. They also need to learn how to transition between hands

smoothly, without getting stuck on one side. Train that transition on its own before building a full luring flow.

If your dog struggles to follow the lure, slow down and go back a few steps. Make the movement slower, shorter, and easier to follow. Create success before adding difficulty.

Luring is not a race. Every dog learns at their own pace, and our job is to make it as clear as possible from the very first moment.

Don't be in a hurry to remove the treats or the lure. It's better to take the time to make it clear rather than having to revisit the exercise because you rushed your dog.

Eye Contact & Self Control

The Eye Contact & Self Control game is all about accuracy, coordination and timing. This behavior is one of the hardest things we ask of a dog, even though it feels completely natural to us, but in this game we teach it step by step, with as little pressure as possible.

Why do we play this game?

This exercise teaches self control and visual communication at the same time.

Your dog learns to resist the treat in your hand and wait for your decision instead of trying to grab the reward. But the real goal goes further than that. We want your dog to not just give up on the treat, but to look at you instead — choosing eye contact over food as the way to make the reward happen.

What makes this game especially meaningful is the visual language it builds. The open hand and the closed hand become signals your dog learns to read. When the hand closes, your dog knows they made a mistake and need to change their behavior. When the hand opens, it's a sign they are on the right track — but they still need to wait for your verbal confirmation before taking the treat.

This connects directly to the luring language we already started building, adding a new layer of communication between you and your dog.

How to play

This exercise has two distinct parts. Start with self control, and only move to eye contact once your dog is comfortable with the first part.

Part 1: Self Control

Hold a treat in your closed fist and place it close to your dog's nose. Wait. No matter what they do, pawing, nudging, whining, keep your hand closed and don't move it. The moment they stop trying to get the treat, mark and reward.

Repeat until your dog starts to understand that backing off is what makes the reward happen. Then slowly open your hand with the treat visible. Your dog should now ignore it. If they move toward it or try to

take it, close your hand again. Reopen only once they have backed off and settled.

Make sure to practice with both hands so your dog understands the behavior is not tied to one side.

Part 2: Eye Contact

Once your dog is comfortable with self control around an open hand, hold both hands closed in front of them and slowly open them apart. Reward your dog for keeping their eyes on your face rather than on the treats. When your dog understands this, you can start adding a verbal cue before opening your hands.

From there, begin creating small distractions by moving your hands while your dog looks at you. If they look away, either start the sequence again or simply stop moving and wait for them to look back before continuing.

Keep gradually adding more distractions, and make sure to practice with empty hands too. Opening your hands with nothing in them should eventually become an eye contact cue on its own.



A few things to keep in mind

Teaching a dog to look us in the eyes is sometimes harder than we expect. To understand why, we first need to remember that in dog

language, direct eye contact can be a way to challenge or even threaten another dog. Because of this, eye contact may not come naturally to every dog, and patience is essential.

Every dog has a different frustration threshold, so to prevent pressure building up before your dog knows how to handle it, it's both allowed and recommended to reinforce steps along the way. For example, if your dog looks away from your fist, even just for a moment, you can mark and reward that. It tells them they're heading in the right direction. Just be careful not to over-reinforce that specific step, since the goal is self control, not avoidance.

When rewarding, always deliver the treat from the opposite hand to the one your dog last looked at. If your dog looked at your right hand before giving up on the treat or looking at you, reward from your left, and vice versa. This keeps the exercise clean and prevents your dog from learning to simply look away from the hand that has the treat.

Practice this exercise in different environments and with your dog in different positions, sitting, standing, lying down, and more. Once your dog understands the behavior, start changing your own position as well. This helps your dog learn to offer eye contact regardless of what you are doing or how you are positioned.

If your dog is especially sensitive or fearful, it may take them longer to offer eye contact freely. In these cases, reward even very small steps toward it.

Don't wait for perfection. Confidence is built one small step at a time.

Follow Up

Follow Up is Reinforce & Release, grown up. Same position, same commitment, but now your dog has to think, move, and stay with you at the same time, even when the treat is no longer there.

Why do we play this game?

The Follow Up game prepares your dog for the front position, one of the most used positions throughout training. It builds mental endurance, patience, and the ability to stay focused while waiting for confirmation.

It's a natural progression from Reinforce & Release. Instead of rewarding your dog in every step, you now praise them for following you in motion, using your Keep Going marker to keep them engaged without relying on treats.

Beyond the front position itself, this game builds concentration, the ability to handle distractions, and duration of focus during movement, skills that will carry into everything we build from here.

How to play

Start by playing a few repetitions of Reinforce & Release to warm your dog up and get them into the game. Then, instead of giving an immediate reward, use your Keep Going marker to keep your dog engaged as you take one more step backwards. After that extra step, stop and use multiple Static Confirmations with a treat in every repetition, then release your dog.

When your dog comes back from the release, play the normal Reinforce & Release version a few more times before challenging them again with Follow Up. During the Follow Up, try to hold your hands behind your back or at your sides so your dog has to think about the position in front of you, rather than following your hands.

Slowly start increasing the duration of each repetition. Use your Keep Going marker as you walk backwards, praising your dog for staying in front of you and maintaining focus while in motion. Reward only when you give the Static Confirmation marker.

Keep building the game and combine it naturally with Reinforce & Release, moving between the two so your dog learns to stay engaged through both stillness and movement.

A few things to keep in mind

This game is one of the most important reads you have as a handler. Think of it this way: if your dog can follow for 10 seconds, they can hold a sequence for 5. If they can do it for 2 minutes, they are ready to dance for one. Use this game to understand where your dog actually is, not where you hope they are.

Many people skip this game or teach the front position through luring instead and the dog becomes dependent on the hands rather than truly understanding the position.

Here, your dog learns to hold the position on their own, which means you can eventually move your hands freely without losing their focus. That is what makes it stick.

That's why it's important to keep your hands behind your back or at your sides as much as possible during the game and only start to move them as distractions at first.

Combine this game regularly with Reinforce & Release. Since Follow Up asks more of your dog, longer duration and no treats between steps, returning to Reinforce & Release between repetitions helps prevent frustration and keeps the difficulty from feeling like it only ever goes up. Moving between the two keeps your dog engaged, and motivated.